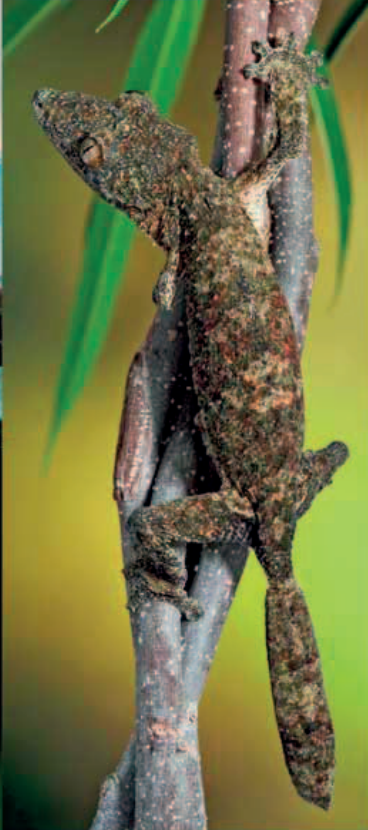




FOREWORD

We share the world with an extraordinary diversity of wildlife, the breadth and depth of which is, frankly, wonderful. As our ancestors traveled through the continents of planet Earth, they encountered amazing animals in each new area they explored. This “biogeography”—or how species are geographically distributed throughout different natural habitats—is something you can now experience for yourself in the following pages, by discovering which animals inhabit each continent’s ecosystems. It is the aim of this book to present a visually compelling exploration of the world’s ecoregions by summarizing the creatures that live there, as well as providing key facts about their life cycles and biology.

More than 40 ecoregions are described in depth, and all are complemented by a spectacular view of the animals—both the familiar and the less well-known—that inhabit them. By grouping species together within their natural habitats, it becomes easy to spot the top predators in each one, as well as the variety of creatures that live alongside them. Combining this global view with the very best the world of wildlife photography has to offer allows us to take you on a journey that can be completed in a variety of ways, but always at your own pace, and in the comfort of your home.

Most people are familiar with the animals, large and small, that share the regions in which we live. The current age of easy worldwide travel has allowed some of us to experience more exotic parts of the globe, where the animals are unfamiliar, different, and sometimes very strange indeed. Yet this diversity of habitats and organisms is, sadly, diminishing as the world becomes ever more populated with humans, and the impact of those increasing populations takes a heavy toll on natural areas worldwide.

The more we can learn about the diversity of wildlife on our planet, the easier and more effective it will be to design and implement conservation programs that ensure we retain species for future generations. As you make your way through this stunning compilation of our planet’s amazing animals, enjoy the wonder and spectacle of life on Earth and take a moment to realize just how lucky we are to be a part of it—in our own time and place.

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